

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Difficult Conversation Planner

Prepare for the conversation you have been avoiding so you enter it calm, specific and focused on a shared outcome.

Purpose

Difficult conversations go badly when we improvise them under stress. The disagreement over a deadline, the pushback from a sceptical peer, the feedback nobody wants to give — these are the moments a QA leader is really judged on. This planner slows you down beforehand so you separate the facts from your story about them, understand the other person's world, and walk in with a clear ask and a genuine willingness to be moved.

It is built to keep the conversation on the problem rather than the person, and to protect the working relationship even when you disagree. Preparation is not scripting — it is knowing your facts, your intent and your desired outcome well enough to stay flexible in the room.

When to use it

- Challenging a decision from someone more senior or more powerful than you.
- Raising a quality or risk concern you know will be unwelcome.
- Addressing a peer whose behaviour is undermining the team or the work.
- Any conversation you have caught yourself rehearsing in the shower or putting off for days — that avoidance is the signal.

Note: for performance concerns about someone who reports to you, use the Performance Conversation Planner instead, which is built for that specific duty of care.

Instructions

1. Name the real issue in one sentence. If you cannot, you are not ready to have the conversation.
2. Separate fact from story. Write what actually happened (observable, agreed) apart from the meaning you have attached to it. Most heat lives in the story.
3. Step into their shoes. What pressure are they under? What do they want and fear? What might they know that you do not?
4. Decide your outcome: what does a good result look like for the relationship and for the problem, not just "winning"?
5. Plan your opening — factual, non-accusatory, and honest about your intent. Open with the shared goal, not the grievance.

6. Anticipate two or three likely reactions and how you will respond without escalating.
7. Know your ask and your flex: the specific thing you are requesting, and where you can genuinely give ground.
8. Choose the right setting: private, unhurried, and with enough time.

Worked example

Situation: Tom Fielding (Head of Product) has committed to a Friday release for a payments-adjacent feature. The QA lead believes the residual risk is too high because the payments critical paths have not been adequately tested and staging has been unstable all week. This is a challenge upward, to a reasonable but date-driven stakeholder.

Planner section	Worked entry
The real issue (one sentence)	We are on track to ship a payments change on Friday with untested critical paths, and I need Tom to make that go/no-go decision with the real risk in front of him.
Facts (observable)	Two of the four payments critical paths have no test coverage this cycle. Staging has been down or holding stale data on three of the last five days. The legacy billing service is in the blast radius of this change.
My story (to hold lightly)	"Product always rams dates through and treats QA as an obstacle." — a story, not a fact. Tom has been reasonable before when shown clear risk.
Their world	Tom has a growth commitment tied to this date and has likely told his own stakeholders it ships Friday. He fears QA becoming a late, opaque blocker. He is not reckless; he is uninformed about this specific risk.
My outcome	Tom owns an informed go/no-go. Ideally we agree either a short slip to cover the two critical paths, or a reduced scope that ships safely on Friday. Relationship stays strong: QA is his risk radar, not his roadblock.
My opening	"Tom, I want Friday to work as much as you do, and I want you to make the call with the full picture. Can I walk you through where the real risk sits on this one and the options I see?"
Likely reactions	(1) "We committed to Friday." (2) "Can't you just test it faster?" (3) "How bad is the risk, really?"
My responses	(1) "Understood — I'm not saying no to Friday; I'm saying here is what shipping Friday as-is carries." (2) "We can, on the parts that matter — that's the reduced-scope option." (3) Show the two uncovered critical paths and the legacy billing blast radius in plain terms.
My ask	Either a two-day slip to cover the two critical payments paths, or ship Friday with the untested paths feature-flagged off.
My flex	I do not need the whole feature delayed. Any option that keeps untested payments paths out of customers' hands on Friday meets my concern.
Setting	A 20-minute private call today, well before the Friday crunch — not in tomorrow's crowded release stand-up.

Why this works: it hands Tom the decision rather than fighting him for it, presents facts he cannot easily dispute, offers him a way to keep his date (reduced scope) so he is not cornered, and reinforces the relationship the QA lead wants — informer, not blocker.

Blank reusable version

Planner section	Your entry
The real issue (one sentence)	
Facts (observable, agreed)	
My story (to hold lightly)	
Their world (pressures, wants, fears)	
My outcome (problem + relationship)	
My opening line	
Likely reactions	
My responses (without escalating)	
My specific ask	
My flex (where I can give ground)	
Setting (where / when)	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Rehearsing a script and then clinging to it when the real conversation goes elsewhere. Leading with your grievance instead of the shared goal. Presenting your story ("you always...") as if it were fact. Arriving to win rather than to solve. Ambushing someone in public or at a bad moment. Doing all the talking — if you have not planned questions and left room to be persuaded, it is a lecture, not a conversation. And avoiding it altogether until resentment has hardened the position on both sides.

How to interpret / use it well

- The facts-versus-story split is the highest-value step. Most of the charge in a difficult conversation lives in the story; strip it out and the facts are usually manageable.
- Genuine flex is not weakness — it is what makes the other person willing to move too. Decide it in advance so you are not improvising concessions under pressure.
- Hand over the decision where it rightly belongs. With a stakeholder like Tom, your job is to inform the choice, not to make it for him.
- Prepare, then let the plan go. The plan is to steady your nerves and sharpen your thinking, not to control the other person.
- Debrief afterwards: what landed, what you misjudged about their world, what to do differently next time.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The line that defuses almost any upward challenge is "I want the same outcome you do, and I want you to decide with the full picture." It reframes you from opponent to ally in a single sentence, and it is only credible if it is true — so make it true before you walk in.